Velmora: Plan for the 6 weeks before Black Friday

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For Velmora, Black Friday is more so a deadline rather than a sale. Most Velmora pieces are made to order in 14 to 21 days, and the studio can make about 20 a week. For a 21-day piece, the last UK order date to arrive by Christmas is 28 November, the day after Black Friday, so delivery certainty is worth more to Velmora's customers than a discount. The three changes below are the ones I believe the analytics point to. Over the six months, Velmora took 239 orders worth £80,440, an average of £337 per order, or £185 of gross profit at its 55% margin. Adding up the estimates below (about 9 extra orders a month from change 1, 4 from change 2 and 4 to 9 from change 3), the three changes could bring 17 to 22 more orders a month, or about £5.7k to £7.4k at £337 each, taking orders from about 11 to 15 or 16 a week, still under the studio's limit of 20.

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1. Fix mobile checkout, starting with Instagram visitors

DATA EVIDENCE: Checkout struggles on phones and mostly for Instagram. Direct visitors complete 71% of their checkouts on desktop but only 27% on mobile. Instagram visitors complete 36% on desktop and just 12% on mobile. Instagram on mobile accounts for 49% of started checkouts but only 23% of orders, so that is where most sales are lost. They start checkout at the usual rate (55% of add-to-carts), and average order is the same on mobile and desktop (£338 and £336), so they want to buy and something stops them paying. My guess is friction in the mobile checkout itself, made worse by Instagram's in-app browser, which usually has no saved logins or wallets.

FIX: In week one, use an iPhone and an Android phone in Safari, Chrome and Instagram's browser, to note where mobile checkout breaks. Meanwhile, email people who abandoned checkout with a link to finish in Safari or Chrome (88 Instagram-mobile checkouts failed in September). In the next weeks, fix a smoother mobile (and Instagram) checkout by adding express wallets (Shop Pay, Apple Pay, Google Pay), guest checkout and an "open in browser" prompt.

EXPECTED IMPACT: In September, 99 Instagram visitors on phones started checkout and 11 finished (11%). Raising that to 20% would mean about 9 more orders a month (around £3k). Each extra 10% of checkouts completed is worth about 10 orders, or £3.4k. Other mobile traffic should improve too, adding more on top.

MEASURED BY: The checkout-to-order rate for Instagram on mobile (11% in September, target 20%) and for all mobile traffic (11% in September), weekly, before and after the fix. Desktop is the comparison, since the fix shouldn't affect it so desktop conversion (54%) and average order (£337) should stay roughly where they are.

2. Show delivery dates on product pages and in the cart

DATA EVIDENCE: 45% of carts (797 of 1,779) never reach checkout, and that is consistent every month on both devices. That looks like hesitation across the whole site rather than a bug. brand.md says customers choose on fit, fabric and delivery date, and 38 of the 48 pieces take 14 to 21 days to make before 3 to 8 days of shipping, requiring pre-planning for occasion pieces.

FIX: On every product page, and again in the cart, show when the piece would arrive if ordered today and the last order dates for 24 and 31 December, and say clearly when a date can't be met. The concept site already does this on every product page.

EXPECTED IMPACT: If an extra 5% of carts reached checkout, that means about 23 more checkouts and 4 more orders a month at September's 19% completion, and even more once change 1 is in. I've assumed a rise to 60%, which is untested.

MEASURED BY: Monthly Cart-Checkout rate. Baseline 55%, target 60%. It has stayed within one point for six months, so a real change will be easy to see. For this, promised on-time delivery must be met and a max of 20 made-to-order orders must be met.

3. Grow the email list with deadline reminders

DATA EVIDENCE: Email is 5.5% of sessions but 22% of orders. It makes up 21.7% of orders – more than instagram's 4.6%. Even though email sessions have stayed between 238 and 333 a month, it has the highest conversion rate of all channels.

FIX: Add a sign-up offering Christmas order-by dates and early access to the nine ready-to-ship pieces, rather than a discount. Then send three emails: around 20 November for the 21-day cut-off, on 27 November for the ready-to-ship pieces, and around 1 December for the 14-day cut-off.

EXPECTED IMPACT: Every extra 100 email sessions should bring 1.4 to 3 orders (£450 to £980). If November email sessions double to about 600, that is 4 to 9 more orders.

MEASURED BY: Orders from email in November against the six-month average (9 in September - target 13 to 18), plus sign-ups per week. The unsubscribe rate and studio load should be tracked alongside.

Secondary Points

- **No Black Friday discount on made-to-order pieces:** At a 55% margin, an average £337 order leaves £185 of gross profit after the £152 it costs to make. With 20% off, the customer pays £270 but the cost stays the same, so gross profit falls to £118. Velmora would need 57% more orders just to earn the same, more than the studio can produce. So, if there has to be an offer, it should be on the ready-to-ship pieces.
- **Pause paid social until checkout is fixed:** £2,700 of ads brought in £3,376 of sales, which at a 55% margin is £1,857 of gross profit, a loss of about £840. To break even, every £1 of ads needs to bring in £1.82 of sales (£1 ÷ 0.55). This test brought in £1.25. And 90% of those visitors were on phones, where only 6% of their checkouts completed.